

Sentient Others at the Edge: Precautionary Play in Ecocritical Games

Digital games are potentially transformative sites for remodelling anthropocentric frameworks that traditionally shape environmental discourse and imaginaries (Morton 2016; Chang 2019; Backe 2024). This presentation aims to contribute to emerging conversations in ecocritical game studies by drawing upon Jonathan Birch's precautionary ethical framework presented in *The Edge Sentience* (2024). I aim to connect in-game enemies, animals and other relevant environmental agents as 'sentience candidates' to better understand games as critical sites for reimagining questions of sentience, multispecies entanglement and ethical agency in uncertain climate and environmental futures (Heise 2009; Sicart 2011; Abraham and Jayemanne 2017).

Within the realm of ethics and our relation to animals and non-human sentient systems, Birch characterises the epistemic situation of sentience as marked by persistent theoretical uncertainty, since phenomenal consciousness and valence remain contested. Rather than presenting metaphysical resolutions, he proposes a precautionary principle-based, policy-oriented framework grounded on what he terms sentience candidature. Meaning, even when a being cannot be clearly determined to be sentient or non-sentient, if there is reasonable cause for it to become a realistic candidate for sentience, ignoring the risk of causing suffering to that being would constitute negligence, and precaution should be proportionate to that risk. In such cases, the uncertainty surrounding sentience itself is ethically salient enough to warrant moral consideration. Emphasising the philosopher as an elucidator and a 'proposer', Birch highlights several proposals that may benefit relevant discussions regarding uncertain futures (Kitcher 2011; Birch 2024).

Games such as *ARC Raiders* (Embark Studios 2025), *Left 4 Dead* (Valve 2008), and *Stardew Valley* (ConcernedApe 2016) have treated zombies, robots, and animals as non-candidates for moral consideration. Existing research on zombie antagonists highlights their broader sociopolitical significance of alterity and their function as an ideal enemy, representing a "post-human Other" without consciousness or human traits (Boon 2011; Barr 2014; Aarseth and Backe 2014; Webley 2022). These enemies infrequently exhibit any affective or valenced experiences, allowing players to act without ethical consideration.

Games that include artificial intelligence and robot adversaries further broaden this dynamic with emergent sentience. In *Nier: Automata* (PlatinumGames 2017), machines initially appear as hostile antagonists, only to reveal grief and sociality within communities later, as in Pascal's Village. This retrospective categorisation of sentience complicates the player's earlier violence, as while machines were plausible candidates for sentience, precaution was waived. *BioShock* (2K 2007) also presents this logic through the Little Sisters, biologically-altered girls conditioned to reap volatile, biological

substances from corpses. The player can either harvest them, betting against possible sentience, or spare them, enacting precautionary restraint against their capacity to suffer. Birch's central claim is dramatised digitally across these scenarios where moral status is uncertain in the face of alternative forms of sentience and thus, creating difficulties in calibrating actions. This framework is relevant to the growing research on climate futures and ecocritical video games, as it offers opportunities to explore evolving forms of sentience and embodiment by foregrounding relational and non-human candidates.

The ending sequence of *The Pale Beyond* (Fellow Traveller 2023) exemplifies this potential. In this survival role-playing game, the player manages a crew stranded on an Arctic expedition after their ship gets stuck in the ice and the captain disappears. When the player finally discovers the abandoned ship they were seeking, it has been overgrown by a potentially sentient tree whose fruit grants the player/character the (meta)ability to perceive and traverse multiple timelines/playthroughs. The original captain, having encountered the tree in a prior loop, has repeatedly relived the expedition to save the crew and avoid getting stranded. The player can then either return the ship and the tree to the corporation sponsoring the expedition, whose motives are unclear, or destroy both to prevent unknown consequences, if any.

Notably, the tree does not communicate or display recognisable emotions, yet its ambiguous nature and the uncertainty about any potential negative impact constitute a genuine moral risk. In this way, the tree occupies what Birch describes as a practical edge of sentience: neither fully sentient nor inert, dismissing its moral status or significance is not entirely straightforward, making the consequential dilemma acute. The science fantasy roguelike epic *Caves of Qud* (Freehold Games 2015) explores a similar vein, enabling encounters with beings with radically differing cognition, such as sentient plants. From a game-philosophical perspective, these games represent alternative approaches to uncertainty, sentience, and risk in relation to plants, animals, and other non-human candidates. Rather than framing ethics as a matter of binary choice, these games foreground precaution and destabilisation of common paradigms.

This reframing gains particular urgency in the context of animal-oriented games. Animals are frequently embedded in the game landscape as harvestable matter, companions, or anthropomorphised characters. Even when in-game animal killing mirrors morally permissible real-world practices, such as hunting for survival in *Red Dead Redemption 2* (Rockstar Games 2018), the broader sociocultural marginalisation of animals renders such violence ethically tenuous (Coghlan and Sparrow 2020). Moreover, the under-current of anthropocentric hegemony perpetuates the human-animal divide, where even games with non-human main characters cannot help but anthropomorphise them (Fuchs 2021). For example, cozy games like *Winter Burrow* (Noodlecake 2025), in which players control a mouse refurbishing its home and gathering resources, largely

reinforce familiar, anthropocentric perspectives rather than offering novel experiences of the non-human (Pinder 2024). On the other hand, animal mayhem games, which create playful animal gameplay, “destabilize and defamiliarize the player’s assumptions about the passivity of the nonhuman” rather than produce simple identification with or representation of the non-human (Caracciolo 2021). As a medium, video games have the potential to explore “the radical otherness” in meaningful ways, as such, creating embodied experiences of sentience, agency, and relationality in other life forms to further challenge anthropocentric ontologies (Sabloff 2001). In this regard, *Fe* (EA 2018), a game in which you play a fox-like creature, using non-verbal communication through sound and melody to connect the player-fox to the ecosystem and its inhabitants, subverts anthropomorphic communication whilst creating an intentional environment that is foreign and exploratory (van Veldhoven 2022).

This presentation primarily examines how selected games have handled sentience and moral uncertainty, situating ecocritical and non-human oriented games within the broader post-apocalyptic trajectory in this regard, and integrates Birch’s precautionary ethics as a conceptual framework for understanding design strategies suited to reflective encounters. In the context of the *Playing Futures* conference, this presentation aims to prompt discussion and ideas about games and play as spaces for critically and ethically interacting with uncertainty among agents at the edge of sentience, thus enhancing our capacities to challenge anthropocentric limitations and transform the way we imagine and shape the future.

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